

television but Hollywood is just waking up to Bollywood's potential, having put down \$100 million in it cumulatively so far. Walt Disney, after several false starts, including one bitter fallout with Indian Premier League's current hero, Lalit Modi, back in the days when he was chairman of Modi Entertainment Network, is a strategic investor in UTV with a 32 per cent stake bought for \$200 million. Apart from that, it has a three-animation movie deal with Yash Raj Films, the first of which, *Roadside Romeo*, releases this month. Viacom, apart from its interests in television, has a joint venture with TV18 in the Indian Film Company (IFC), which last year raised \$112 million at London Stock Exchange's Alternative Investment Market. IFC is also in negotiations with CIT, a middle market lender that has done substantial deals in Hollywood, for a

TWENTIETH CENTURY Fox

has just signed a deal with **VIPUL SHAH'S** Blockbuster Entertainment but it has already partnered UTV Motion Pictures on three Hollywood films. UTV co-produced the \$14-million *The Namesake* and the \$7-million *I Think I Love My Wife* with Fox Searchlight and the \$57-million *The Happening* with Fox.



EXTERNAL AFFAIR: Chris Rock (centre) in *I Think I Love My Wife*

\$150-million line of credit. That's not all. Warner Bros is waiting for the release of its first co-production in India with Ramesh Sippy Entertainment and Orion Pictures, the extravagant *Chandni Chowk to China*, even as Sony Pictures Entertainment is recovering from the tanking of its first Hindi film, the \$8-million *Saawariya*, and has announced a co-investment deal with Eros International. And, oh yes, big shots from talent agencies such as the powerful CAA and the pedigreed William Morris have made several rounds of movie producer offices in Bandra and Andheri.

Add to that interest from a whole range of banks and hedge funds which are in the market for co-production deals, though less so after the global meltdown, and clearly everyone seems to want a piece of the India action. Not because of Hollywood movie revenues in India certainly, which even in the best of times are not more than 3 per cent to 5 per cent of the total annual box-office revenue, compared to 88 per cent in a nation like Britain, but also because of the domestic market, which sells 3.7 billion tickets, compared to just 1.4 billion in the US. The revenues currently from India may seem puny, but the studios and film funds are betting on an India of the future where ticket prices will be more than the current average of 20 cents (the US average is \$6), where there will be more than 12,000 screens, and where there is huge potential of growth of the home video market (which currently contributes 8 per cent to the market, compared to over 40 per cent of the total revenue in the US). As Sanford Panitch, president of the newly established Fox

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